Stone Fruit Saison

A mixed-culture saison with a long, cool whirlpool and a generous dry hop

The beer

This is a farmhouse ale in the French tradition: a pale, dry base with a substantial wheat fraction, a firm but restrained bitterness, and the fruit forward character that comes from a cool whirlpool and a two-stage dry hop. We brew it in late spring and let it finish warm.

Our batch is 23 litres into the fermenter, and we aim for an original gravity of 1.052 and a final gravity near 1.006, which puts the beer at about 6.0% ABV. We target 28 IBU and a boil of 75 minutes at a rolling, not violent, rate.

The grist

The grist is simple and built for fermentability. We use 3.4 kg of continental pilsner malt as the backbone, with 900 g of flaked wheat for body and a persistent haze, 450 g of Vienna malt for a little bread crust, and 150 g of acidulated malt to bring the mash pH into line. That is the whole bill: no crystal malts, because we want the beer to finish dry.

We mash in thick, at 63 degrees Celsius, and hold it there for 45 minutes before raising to 72 degrees Celsius for a further 20 minutes, then mashing out at 76 degrees Celsius. Sparge slowly with water at 76 degrees Celsius and stop when the runnings fall below 1.010.

The hops

We bitter with 22 grams of Magnum at the start of the boil, 75 minutes, which does most of the work. With 20 minutes left we add 30 grams of Saaz, and with 5 minutes left another 20 grams of Saaz for flavour. At flameout we drop the temperature to 80 degrees Celsius and hold it there for a 25 minute whirlpool, adding 40 grams of Motueka and 25 grams of Nelson Sauvin. When primary fermentation is finished we dry hop with 50 grams of Motueka for three days, then rack and dry hop again with 30 grams of Nelson Sauvin for another two days.

A further 20 grams of Saaz goes in for aroma at a point we move from batch to batch, depending on how the boil is going and how the last beer tasted; some years it lands late in the boil and some years it waits for the whirlpool. We have never settled on a rule for it, and we do not pretend the number matters more than the taste.

We also keep a bag of whole-cone Saaz to hand and, depending on how the whirlpool tastes on the day, throw a couple of generous handfuls in with the aroma charge. There is no fixed weight for this; it is a matter of taste and we adjust it every year.

The yeast and fermentation

We pitch a blend: a clean saison strain for the bulk of the fermentation and a Brettanomyces culture for the finish. Ferment at 22 degrees Celsius for four days, then let it rise to 26 degrees Celsius and hold for a

week, and finally hold it at 18 degrees Celsius for another two weeks before packaging. Carbonate to 2.6 volumes.